

Ornithomimids

Also known as “ostrich dinosaurs,” the members of the ornithomimid family were built like ostriches and were just as quick on their feet. They were the fastest dinosaurs of all, capable of reaching perhaps 50 mph (80 kph) when running. They evolved from flesh-eaters, but their birdlike beaks and lack of big teeth suggest a more varied diet.

Gallimimus

GAL-ih-MIME-us

- **When** 75–65 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** Mongolia
- **Habitat** Desert plains
- **Length** 20 ft (6 m)
- **Diet** Leaves, seeds, insects, and small animals

One of the best known of all ornithomimids is *Gallimimus* (“chicken mimic”). It was the largest ornithomimid, three times as tall as a man and, at 1,000 lb (450 kg) in weight, a lot

heavier than any chicken. *Gallimimus* was the fastest sprinter of any dinosaur and could have outrun a racehorse. It had a birdlike skull, with a brain about the size of a golf ball (only slightly larger than an ostrich’s). Its long, toothless beak was used to pick up leaves, seeds, insects, and small mammals.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Extremely long legs
- Long necks and small, beaked heads
- Large eyes
- Tiny teeth or no teeth

When

Ornithomimids first appeared in the Early Cretaceous, 130 million years ago. They died out in the Late Cretaceous, 65 million years ago.

◀ BIRD VISION

Gallimimus had wide eye sockets with eyes facing sideways. This helped it spot enemies in almost any direction. Inside each eyeball was a supporting ring of small bony plates. Modern birds still have this feature.



LIVING RELATIVE

Ornithomimids may have run just like ostriches run today. Ostriches take great strides with their powerful, long legs, with their tails jutting out behind. The fastest bird today, an ostrich can run at about 45 miles (72 km) per hour, while an average human can reach only 6–11 mph (10–18 kph).

